ANCIENT-INDIAN-HISTORY-06 | CONTINUOUS CORE-FIRST MASTER

01

TERMINOLOGY, CHRONOLOGY AND THE INTEGRATION-LOCALISATION MODEL — [CORE PRELIMS + CORE MAINS]

CONTEXT + EXACT CORE

INFERENCE: The tripartite scheme describes processes, not three sealed ethnic populations.

MECHANISM / ARGUMENT

INFERENCE: The tripartite scheme describes processes, not three sealed ethnic populations.

CONSEQUENCE / CONTRAST

RECALL: Protohistory here means a literate civilization whose script cannot yet be read.

UPSC TRAP / ANSWER USE

Mature Harappan and Rig Vedic are contemporaneous. || Mature Harappan urbanism largely predates the conventional c. 1500-1000 BCE Rig Vedic horizon.

ANSWER LINE: **FACT: "Harappan" is the safest archaeological label because the culture extended far beyond the Indus valley and the identification of the Ghaggar-Hakra with the Vedic Sarasvati remains debated.**

02

DISCOVERY, EXCAVATION AND CHANGING HISTORIOGRAPHY

CONTEXT + EXACT CORE

TRAP: The first excavator's label proves a structure's function. || Labels must be retested against residue, access, architecture, associated finds and comparison.

MECHANISM / ARGUMENT

FACT: Research moved from spectacular citadels and artefacts toward households, villages, plant and animal remains, human biology, provenance and environmental histories.

CONSEQUENCE / CONTRAST

INFERENCE: New methods have not removed interpretation; they have made the evidentiary chain more explicit.

UPSC TRAP / ANSWER USE

The first excavator's label proves a structure's function. || Labels must be retested against residue, access, architecture, associated finds and comparison.

ANSWER LINE: **MAINS ANGLE: Historiography is a movement from diffusion, monarchy and invasion toward indigenous development, regional variation and multidisciplinary process.**

03

GEOGRAPHICAL EXTENT, ECOLOGICAL ZONES AND REGIONAL DOMAINS — [CORE PRELIMS + CORE MAINS]

CONTEXT + EXACT CORE

MAINS ANGLE: Ecological diversity explains both civilizational resilience and regionally varied pathways of decline.

MECHANISM / ARGUMENT

TRAP: Indus Valley Civilization means all sites lie in the Indus valley. || The distribution includes Afghanistan, the Ghaggar-Hakra zone, Rajasthan, Gujarat and western Uttar Pradesh.

CONSEQUENCE / CONTRAST

Use "vast, multi-ecological zone" rather than one immutable number.

UPSC TRAP / ANSWER USE

Indus Valley Civilization means all sites lie in the Indus valley. || The distribution includes Afghanistan, the Ghaggar-Hakra zone, Rajasthan, Gujarat and western Uttar Pradesh.

ANSWER LINE: **MAINS ANGLE: Ecological diversity explains both civilizational resilience and regionally varied pathways of decline.**

04

FROM EARLIER FARMING COMMUNITIES TO EARLY HARAPPAN URBAN POTENTIAL

CONTEXT + EXACT CORE

INFERENCE: Urbanisation emerged through convergence among regional traditions, craft intensification, exchange, agricultural surplus, leadership and ideology; no single trigger is sufficient.

MECHANISM / ARGUMENT

TRAP: Early Harappan means primitive and unplanned. || Several early settlements were fortified, planned and craft-specialized.

CONSEQUENCE / CONTRAST

MAINS ANGLE: Explain origins as endogenous transformation with inter-regional interaction, not a Mesopotamian colony or one-site diffusion.

UPSC TRAP / ANSWER USE

Early Harappan means primitive and unplanned. || Several early settlements were fortified, planned and craft-specialized.

ANSWER LINE: **INFERENCE: Urbanisation emerged through convergence among regional traditions, craft intensification, exchange, agricultural surplus, leadership and ideology; no single trigger is sufficient.**

05

SETTLEMENT HIERARCHY AND THE URBAN-RURAL SYSTEM — [CORE PRELIMS + CORE MAINS]

CONTEXT + EXACT CORE

INFERENCE: Standardisation across this hierarchy required coordination, but it does not by itself prove one centralized empire.

MECHANISM / ARGUMENT

INFERENCE: Standardisation across this hierarchy required coordination, but it does not by itself prove one centralized empire.

CONSEQUENCE / CONTRAST

RECALL: Allahdino was a small village with precious ornaments, showing that wealth was not confined to great cities.

UPSC TRAP / ANSWER USE

Urban civilization means every Harappan settlement was a city. || The settlement network was predominantly rural and functionally differentiated.

ANSWER LINE: **FACT: The civilization was urban, but most settlements were villages.**

06

SITE ATLAS I - HARAPPA AND MOHENJO-DARO — [CORE PRELIMS + CORE MAINS]

CONTEXT + EXACT CORE

FACT: Mohenjo-daro may have had over 700 wells, including private and neighbourhood wells.

MECHANISM / ARGUMENT

FACT: Mohenjo-daro may have had over 700 wells, including private and neighbourhood wells.

CONSEQUENCE / CONTRAST

Its secure significance is collective engineering; ritual bathing is plausible, not proven.

UPSC TRAP / ANSWER USE

The Great Bath proves a named religion. || It proves sophisticated waterproof public architecture; its ritual meaning is inferred.

ANSWER LINE: **MAINS ANGLE: Pair the two sites to show shared standards plus different public landscapes.**

07

SITE ATLAS II - DHOLAVIRA AND RAKHIGARHI — [CORE PRELIMS + CORE MAINS]

CONTEXT + EXACT CORE

MAINS ANGLE: Dholavira supplies architecture and climate adaptation; Rakhigarhi supplies urban, mortuary and scientific evidence.

MECHANISM / ARGUMENT

MAINS ANGLE: Dholavira supplies architecture and climate adaptation; Rakhigarhi supplies urban, mortuary and scientific evidence.

CONSEQUENCE / CONTRAST

It demonstrates civic display of writing but does not reveal the city's name until the script is deciphered.

UPSC TRAP / ANSWER USE

Rakhigarhi DNA settled every question of Harappan identity. || One low-coverage ancient genome was a major beginning, not a complete population history.

ANSWER LINE: **TRAP: Rakhigarhi DNA settled every question of Harappan identity. || One low-coverage ancient genome was a major beginning, not a complete population history.**

08

SITE ATLAS III - KALIBANGAN, LOTHAL AND BANAWALI — [CORE PRELIMS + CORE MAINS]

CONTEXT + EXACT CORE

FACT: Kalibangan's lower town lacked the Mohenjo-daro type street drains; household wastewater could empty into jars or troughs outside.

MECHANISM / ARGUMENT

FACT: Kalibangan's lower town lacked the Mohenjo-daro type street drains; household wastewater could empty into jars or troughs outside.

CONSEQUENCE / CONTRAST

This is regional variation, not urban failure.

UPSC TRAP / ANSWER USE

Every fire installation proves Vedic ritual continuity. || Shape, context, chronology and associated remains must be tested first.

ANSWER LINE: **A reservoir interpretation exists but is less persuasive in Upinder Singh's assessment.**

09

SITE ATLAS IV - SURKOTADA, CHANHUDARO AND OTHER STRATEGIC SITES

CONTEXT + EXACT CORE

INFERENCE: Chanhudaro proves that major craft production could occur in a town without the monumental form of Mohenjo-daro.

MECHANISM / ARGUMENT

INFERENCE: Chanhudaro proves that major craft production could occur in a town without the monumental form of Mohenjo-daro.

CONSEQUENCE / CONTRAST

The humped bull and cattle economy are much more characteristic.

UPSC TRAP / ANSWER USE

A reported horse bone makes the horse a defining Harappan animal. || Identification, context and frequency are all disputed.

ANSWER LINE: **FACT: Horse remains are rare and disputed; the mature civilization was not horse-centred.**

10

TOWN PLANNING, ARCHITECTURE AND BUILT STANDARDS — [CORE PRELIMS + CORE MAINS]

CONTEXT + EXACT CORE

FACT: Streets often followed planned alignments, but even Mohenjo-daro did not have a perfect universal grid.

MECHANISM / ARGUMENT

Houses usually opened into side lanes and were arranged around courtyards.

CONSEQUENCE / CONTRAST

RECALL: Baked bricks were concentrated in drains, wells, baths and important structures at many sites; mud-brick remained fundamental.

UPSC TRAP / ANSWER USE

Planned layout means every city followed one blueprint. || Dholavira, Kalibangan, Lothal and smaller settlements show distinct plans.

ANSWER LINE: **FACT: Streets often followed planned alignments, but even Mohenjo-daro did not have a perfect universal grid.**

11

WATER, SANITATION, DRAINAGE AND COLLECTIVE MAINTENANCE — [CORE PRELIMS + CORE MAINS]

CONTEXT + EXACT CORE

RECALL: Sewage channels and rainwater collection were not necessarily the same system.

MECHANISM / ARGUMENT

INFERENCE: Infrastructure required repeated maintenance by workers whose social position is archaeologically under-visible.

CONSEQUENCE / CONTRAST

MAINS ANGLE: Water management is a bounded contemporary bridge to urban resilience, not proof that ancient institutions were identical to modern municipalities.

UPSC TRAP / ANSWER USE

Drains prove modern public health ideas. || They prove practical sanitation and engineering; motives such as ritual purity remain inferential.

ANSWER LINE: **RECALL: Sewage channels and rainwater collection were not necessarily the same system.**

12

PUBLIC STRUCTURES, CRAFT ZONES AND THE PROBLEM OF FUNCTIONAL LABELS — [CORE PRELIMS + CORE MAINS]

CONTEXT + EXACT CORE

TRAP: A large building is automatically a palace, temple or state warehouse. || Function requires converging contextual evidence.

MECHANISM / ARGUMENT

INFERENCE: Public buildings reveal labour mobilisation, but the responsible institution could have been rulers, councils, merchants, ritual specialists or combined authorities.

CONSEQUENCE / CONTRAST

RECALL: Use quotation marks around contested labels in Mains answers.

UPSC TRAP / ANSWER USE

A large building is automatically a palace, temple or state warehouse. || Function requires converging contextual evidence.

ANSWER LINE: **FACT: Craft areas are better identified when raw material, waste, tools, unfinished pieces and furnaces occur together.**

13

AGRICULTURE, CROPS, SEASONS AND FOOD SURPLUS — [CORE PRELIMS + CORE MAINS]

CONTEXT + EXACT CORE

FACT: Agriculture was the mainstay, but crop packages varied regionally.

MECHANISM / ARGUMENT

RECALL: Shortughai has canal evidence; Allahdino irrigation from wells is suggested but not conclusive.

CONSEQUENCE / CONTRAST

TRAP: No surviving ploughshare means no ploughing. || Furrows and terracotta plough models support wooden-plough cultivation.

UPSC TRAP / ANSWER USE

No surviving ploughshare means no ploughing. || Furrows and terracotta plough models support wooden-plough cultivation.

ANSWER LINE: **FACT: Agriculture was the mainstay, but crop packages varied regionally.**

14

PASTORALISM, MEAT, DAIRY, FISHING AND ENVIRONMENTAL RESOURCE USE

CONTEXT + EXACT CORE

MAINS ANGLE: Use archaeobotany plus zooarchaeology plus residue analysis to reconstruct a diversified food system.

MECHANISM / ARGUMENT

FACT: Cattle and buffalo were central; sheep, goats, pigs, dogs and cats also occur.

CONSEQUENCE / CONTRAST

FACT: The horse is rare, debated and not characteristic.

UPSC TRAP / ANSWER USE

An animal on a seal was necessarily domesticated or worshipped. || Representation can be economic, symbolic, mythical or ritual.

ANSWER LINE: **Camels may have been known, but their Harappan context and economic importance remain uncertain.**

15

CRAFT PRODUCTION, METALLURGY AND TECHNICAL SKILL — [CORE PRELIMS + CORE MAINS]

CONTEXT + EXACT CORE

FACT: The bronze "Dancing Girl" was made by lost-wax casting.

MECHANISM / ARGUMENT

FACT: The bronze "Dancing Girl" was made by lost-wax casting.

CONSEQUENCE / CONTRAST

TRAP: Bronze Age means every tool was bronze. || Copper, bronze, stone, shell, bone, wood and terracotta coexisted.

UPSC TRAP / ANSWER USE

Bronze Age means every tool was bronze. || Copper, bronze, stone, shell, bone, wood and terracotta coexisted.

ANSWER LINE: **FACT: Pure copper objects were more numerous than bronze objects; alloys were selected especially where harder edges were useful.**

16

ART AND MATERIAL CULTURE - SCULPTURE, POTTERY, TERRACOTTAS AND TOYS — [CORE PRELIMS + CORE MAINS]

CONTEXT + EXACT CORE

INFERENCE: Differences in materials, skill and distribution may reflect audience, function and access, not a simple high-art/low-art hierarchy.

MECHANISM / ARGUMENT

INFERENCE: Differences in materials, skill and distribution may reflect audience, function and access, not a simple high-art/low-art hierarchy.

CONSEQUENCE / CONTRAST

TRAP: A modern museum nickname is an ancient identity. || Use the nickname for recall but state its interpretive status.

UPSC TRAP / ANSWER USE

A modern museum nickname is an ancient identity. || Use the nickname for recall but state its interpretive status.

ANSWER LINE: **FACT: Seals are among the finest artistic products, but terracottas range from carefully modelled to quickly made objects for everyday or short-term use.**

17

WEIGHTS, MEASURES, GEOMETRY AND EVIDENCE OF SCIENTIFIC KNOWLEDGE — [CORE PRELIMS + CORE MAINS]

CONTEXT + EXACT CORE

FACT: The 2026 Prelims PYQ correctly treats weights and graduated scales as evidence of scientific knowledge, while rejecting a property-system inference from house form.

MECHANISM / ARGUMENT

INFERENCE: Standardization could arise through state regulation, merchant coordination, hereditary specialists, exchange networks or combinations of these.

CONSEQUENCE / CONTRAST

Smaller units follow a binary progression, while higher units include decimal relationships.

UPSC TRAP / ANSWER USE

"Multiple of 16" alone describes the whole weight system. || Smaller and larger series show binary and decimal patterning.

ANSWER LINE: **FACT: The 2026 Prelims PYQ correctly treats weights and graduated scales as evidence of scientific knowledge, while rejecting a property-system inference from house form.**

18

SEALS, SEALINGS AND THE UNDECIPHERED SCRIPT — [CORE PRELIMS + CORE MAINS]

CONTEXT + EXACT CORE

Textile impressions on some sealings support authentication of goods, but seals also show wear and suspension holes consistent with other functions.

MECHANISM / ARGUMENT

Most inscriptions are short, averaging about five signs; the longest has 26 signs.

CONSEQUENCE / CONTRAST

RECALL: Do not call the whole script boustrophedon.

UPSC TRAP / ANSWER USE

A proposed Dravidian, Sanskrit or non-linguistic reading is settled. || Competing proposals exist; no decipherment is accepted.

ANSWER LINE: **Textile impressions on some sealings support authentication of goods, but seals also show wear and suspension holes consistent with other functions.**

19

INTERNAL EXCHANGE, RAW MATERIALS AND TRANSPORT — [CORE PRELIMS + CORE MAINS]

CONTEXT + EXACT CORE

TRAP: A non-local bead proves conquest or colony. || It proves movement; the mechanism may be trade, gifting, mobility or down-the-line exchange.

MECHANISM / ARGUMENT

TRAP: A non-local bead proves conquest or colony. || It proves movement; the mechanism may be trade, gifting, mobility or down-the-line exchange.

CONSEQUENCE / CONTRAST

FACT: Two-wheeled carts with solid wheels, pack animals, river boats and seagoing craft are supported by models, tracks and depictions.

UPSC TRAP / ANSWER USE

A non-local bead proves conquest or colony. || It proves movement; the mechanism may be trade, gifting, mobility or down-the-line exchange.

ANSWER LINE: **INFERENCE: Internal exchange was more structurally important than the visually attractive but limited Mesopotamian trade.**

20

LONG-DISTANCE TRADE, MELUHHA AND THE MESOPOTAMIAN LINK — [CORE PRELIMS + CORE MAINS]

CONTEXT + EXACT CORE

TRAP: Mesopotamian trade caused Harappan urbanism. || It may have enriched exchange, but chronology and low find quantities undermine a monocausal claim.

MECHANISM / ARGUMENT

Dilmun is generally identified with Bahrain; Magan with Oman/Makran; Meluhha probably included the Indus region but its exact scope is debated.

CONSEQUENCE / CONTRAST

RECALL: Dilmun and Magan were intermediating regions, not Harappan cities.

UPSC TRAP / ANSWER USE

Mesopotamian trade caused Harappan urbanism. || It may have enriched exchange, but chronology and low find quantities undermine a monocausal claim.

ANSWER LINE: **TRAP: Mesopotamian trade caused Harappan urbanism. || It may have enriched exchange, but chronology and low find quantities undermine a monocausal claim.**

21

SOCIAL ORGANISATION, WEALTH AND OCCUPATIONAL DIVERSITY

CONTEXT + EXACT CORE

INFERENCE: Rank and class differences probably existed, but claims of a Harappan caste system are highly speculative.

MECHANISM / ARGUMENT

INFERENCE: Rank and class differences probably existed, but claims of a Harappan caste system are highly speculative.

CONSEQUENCE / CONTRAST

RECALL: Material culture can suggest inequality more securely than it can name legal status.

UPSC TRAP / ANSWER USE

FACT: House size, location, craft access, ornaments, hoards, diet and burials indicate differentiation, but there are no royal tombs or lavish elite burials comparable to Egypt and Mesopotamia.

ANSWER LINE: **FACT: House size, location, craft access, ornaments, hoards, diet and burials indicate differentiation, but there are no royal tombs or lavish elite burials comparable to Egypt and Mesopotamia.**

22

POLITY DEBATE - EMPIRE, CITY-STATES, COUNCILS OR CORPORATE ELITES

CONTEXT + EXACT CORE

INFERENCE: The most defensible position is organized authority with uncertain scale, personnel and coercive structure.

MECHANISM / ARGUMENT

TRAP: No palace means no state. || Early states can express authority through infrastructure, standards and networks rather than royal monuments.

CONSEQUENCE / CONTRAST

MAINS ANGLE: Achievement is clear; constitutional form is not.

UPSC TRAP / ANSWER USE

No palace means no state. || Early states can express authority through infrastructure, standards and networks rather than royal monuments.

ANSWER LINE: **FACT: Weapons and narrative scenes of warfare are less prominent than in Mesopotamia and Egypt, but fortifications warn against imagining a coercion-free society.**

23

RELIGION AND RITUAL - INTERPRETATION WITHOUT BACK-PROJECTION

CONTEXT + EXACT CORE

FACT: No structure has been conclusively identified as a monumental temple.

MECHANISM / ARGUMENT

INFERENCE: Harappan ritual was plural, household and civic; a single standardized creed cannot be reconstructed.

CONSEQUENCE / CONTRAST

MAINS ANGLE: Religious interpretation should follow the sequence form - context - comparison - alternative - qualified conclusion.

UPSC TRAP / ANSWER USE

Similarity with later Hindu practice proves direct unchanged continuity. || Resemblance may indicate continuity, reuse, convergence or retrospective projection.

ANSWER LINE: **FACT: Female figurines are abundant at some sites and rare at others, demonstrating regional or functional variation.**

24

GENDER, BURIALS, HEALTH AND THE LIMITS OF SOCIAL RECONSTRUCTION

CONTEXT + EXACT CORE

MAINS ANGLE: Use burial and gender evidence as a lesson in cautious social history, not a route to confident family law.

MECHANISM / ARGUMENT

RECALL: Burial wealth was generally modest compared with Egyptian or Mesopotamian royal tombs.

CONSEQUENCE / CONTRAST

TRAP: Goddess worship means matriarchy. || Divine femininity and ordinary women's authority are separate questions.

UPSC TRAP / ANSWER USE

Goddess worship means matriarchy. || Divine femininity and ordinary women's authority are separate questions.

ANSWER LINE: **MAINS ANGLE: Use burial and gender evidence as a lesson in cautious social history, not a route to confident family law.**

25

DECLINE AND DEURBANISATION - A MULTI-CAUSAL, REGIONAL PROCESS — [CORE PRELIMS + CORE MAINS]

CONTEXT + EXACT CORE

FACT: The mature phase was followed by Late Harappan cultures; people and practices did not vanish.

MECHANISM / ARGUMENT

FACT: The mature phase was followed by Late Harappan cultures; people and practices did not vanish.

CONSEQUENCE / CONTRAST

MAINS ANGLE: Use "metamorphosis/deurbanisation" with causation, regional variation and continuity.

UPSC TRAP / ANSWER USE

One flood, one invasion or one drought ended every city. || Different mechanisms operated at different sites and scales.

ANSWER LINE: **Mohenjo-daro and Dholavira show gradual deterioration, while urban life ended more abruptly at Kalibangan and Banawali.**

26

LATE HARAPPAN CONTINUITY, TRANSFORMATION AND SUCCESSOR CULTURES — [CORE PRELIMS + CORE MAINS]

CONTEXT + EXACT CORE

TRAP: "Continuity" means the entire mature urban system survived unchanged. || Continuity and structural rupture coexisted.

MECHANISM / ARGUMENT

FACT: Late Harappan levels overlap with Painted Grey Ware at some Punjab-Haryana sites and with Ochre Coloured Pottery in western Uttar Pradesh.

CONSEQUENCE / CONTRAST

Overlap shows contact and sequence, not ethnic identity.

UPSC TRAP / ANSWER USE

"Continuity" means the entire mature urban system survived unchanged. || Continuity and structural rupture coexisted.

ANSWER LINE: **RECALL: Continuity is selective: pottery, crops, craft and population can continue even when cities, script and standardized institutions weaken.**

27

RELATIONS WITH NEOLITHIC-CHALCOLITHIC AND VEDIC WORLDS

CONTEXT + EXACT CORE

TRAP: aDNA can label an archaeological culture as a modern ethnic or linguistic group. || Genes, language, material culture and political identity are related but non-identical evidence domains.

MECHANISM / ARGUMENT

INFERENCE: Migration, admixture and cultural interaction are better models than either violent replacement or timeless ethnic identity.

CONSEQUENCE / CONTRAST

RECALL: Genetics does not directly identify language, religion or self-designation.

UPSC TRAP / ANSWER USE

aDNA can label an archaeological culture as a modern ethnic or linguistic group. || Genes, language, material culture and political identity are related but non-identical evidence domains.

ANSWER LINE: **FACT: Mature cities, script, seals and baked-brick urban systems are not characteristic of the Rig Veda.**

28

CURRENT-RESEARCH GUARDRAIL

CONTEXT + EXACT CORE

It must not be used to declare script decipherment, a known polity or one final decline cause.

MECHANISM / ARGUMENT

It must not be used to declare script decipherment, a known polity or one final decline cause.

CONSEQUENCE / CONTRAST

No current-affairs item is required for this static topic.

UPSC TRAP / ANSWER USE

It must not be used to declare script decipherment, a known polity or one final decline cause.

ANSWER LINE: **A new excavation, river study, genome result or conservation report may refine a bounded site-level claim only after a primary publication or official report is checked.**

29

UPSC TRAPS, TERMINOLOGY AND ANSWER-BUILDING RULES

CONTEXT + EXACT CORE

MAINS ANGLE: The qualification should sharpen the answer, not dissolve it into "nothing is known.".

MECHANISM / ARGUMENT

MAINS ANGLE: The qualification should sharpen the answer, not dissolve it into "nothing is known.".

CONSEQUENCE / CONTRAST

MAINS ANGLE: The qualification should sharpen the answer, not dissolve it into "nothing is known.".

UPSC TRAP / ANSWER USE

MAINS ANGLE: The qualification should sharpen the answer, not dissolve it into "nothing is known.".

ANSWER LINE: **MAINS ANGLE: The qualification should sharpen the answer, not dissolve it into "nothing is known.".**

30

PHASE -> PROCESS -> REGIONAL CHANGE — [CORE PRELIMS + CORE MAINS]

CONTEXT + EXACT CORE

Use Early, Mature and Late Harappan as a process sequence: regional foundations - integrated urban traits - de-urbanisation and localisation.

MECHANISM / ARGUMENT

Use Early, Mature and Late Harappan as a process sequence: regional foundations - integrated urban traits - de-urbanisation and localisation.

CONSEQUENCE / CONTRAST

It is not sudden appearance then extinction.

UPSC TRAP / ANSWER USE

A modern archaeological label is not a Harappan self-description.

ANSWER LINE: **Mature urbanism is the core factual phase; Late Harappan continuity prevents a one-line collapse story.**

31

SITE-FEATURE TRIADS, NOT A SITE CATALOGUE

CONTEXT + EXACT CORE

A modern archaeological label is not a Harappan self-description.

MECHANISM / ARGUMENT

A modern archaeological label is not a Harappan self-description.

CONSEQUENCE / CONTRAST

A modern archaeological label is not a Harappan self-description.

UPSC TRAP / ANSWER USE

A modern archaeological label is not a Harappan self-description.

ANSWER LINE: **A modern archaeological label is not a Harappan self-description.**

32

URBAN WATER AND BUILT FORM — [CORE PRELIMS + CORE MAINS]

CONTEXT + EXACT CORE

Grid streets, standard bricks, wells, bathing floors and covered drains securely show planned civic construction and water management.

MECHANISM / ARGUMENT

They do not securely identify kings, a palace, a granary or one central state.

CONSEQUENCE / CONTRAST

A modern archaeological label is not a Harappan self-description.

UPSC TRAP / ANSWER USE

They do not securely identify kings, a palace, a granary or one central state.

ANSWER LINE: **Grid streets, standard bricks, wells, bathing floors and covered drains securely show planned civic construction and water management.**

33

PRODUCTION, MEASUREMENT AND EXCHANGE

CONTEXT + EXACT CORE

The argument should be: evidence of coordination - craft/exchange implication - limit on exact political control.

MECHANISM / ARGUMENT

The argument should be: evidence of coordination - craft/exchange implication - limit on exact political control.

CONSEQUENCE / CONTRAST

A modern archaeological label is not a Harappan self-description.

UPSC TRAP / ANSWER USE

The argument should be: evidence of coordination - craft/exchange implication - limit on exact political control.

ANSWER LINE: **No coinage is known; weights and commodities do not tell us the title of a ruler.**

34

SCRIPT, RITUAL AND AUTHORITY

CONTEXT + EXACT CORE

Seals, figurines, fire installations, burials and monumental-looking buildings can reveal material practice and repeated symbols; they cannot securely disclose doctrine, named gods, caste or a monarchy.

MECHANISM / ARGUMENT

Seals, figurines, fire installations, burials and monumental-looking buildings can reveal material practice and repeated symbols; they cannot securely disclose doctrine, named gods, caste or a monarchy.

CONSEQUENCE / CONTRAST

Use 'horned figure', 'female figurines' and 'structure conventionally called...' before advancing a cautious interpretation.

UPSC TRAP / ANSWER USE

A modern archaeological label is not a Harappan self-description.

ANSWER LINE: **A modern archaeological label is not a Harappan self-description.**

35

DECLINE AS TRANSFORMATION — [CORE PRELIMS + CORE MAINS]

CONTEXT + EXACT CORE

A modern archaeological label is not a Harappan self-description.

MECHANISM / ARGUMENT

A modern archaeological label is not a Harappan self-description.

CONSEQUENCE / CONTRAST

River/environmental change, trade disruption and internal reorganisation are contributory explanations, not a settled single cause.

UPSC TRAP / ANSWER USE

River/environmental change, trade disruption and internal reorganisation are contributory explanations, not a settled single cause.

ANSWER LINE: **River/environmental change, trade disruption and internal reorganisation are contributory explanations, not a settled single cause.**

36

DEEP TEACHING UNIT 1: FROM REGIONAL CULTURES TO URBAN INTEGRATION — [CORE PRELIMS + CORE MAINS]

CONTEXT + EXACT CORE

"Urbanisation began suddenly in 2600 BCE and ended completely in 1900 BCE." Both halves flatten a long, uneven process.

MECHANISM / ARGUMENT

Shared weights and brick conventions are outcomes of repeated choices and coordination; they are not the initial cause of every town.

CONSEQUENCE / CONTRAST

The Late phase is the weakening of this particular urban integration, not the disappearance of every person or practice.

UPSC TRAP / ANSWER USE

Dholavira's distinctive architecture also demonstrates that integration did not erase regional solutions.

ANSWER LINE: **The Early Harappan phase shows several regional communities developing some of these capacities.**

37

DEEP TEACHING UNIT 2: EXTENT, ECOLOGY AND THE URBAN-RURAL SYSTEM — [CORE PRELIMS + CORE MAINS]

CONTEXT + EXACT CORE

A coastal or semi-arid site should not be judged by the same expectations as a riverine city.

MECHANISM / ARGUMENT

A coastal or semi-arid site should not be judged by the same expectations as a riverine city.

CONSEQUENCE / CONTRAST

Extent is an economic map: river plains, coast and resource zones were connected, not identical.

UPSC TRAP / ANSWER USE

Cities therefore depended on villages, pastoral areas and resource routes; they were not self-sufficient islands.

ANSWER LINE: **Ecology creates possibilities and pressures; it does not mechanically determine a political outcome.**

38

DEEP TEACHING UNIT 3: PLANNING, WATER AND EVERYDAY MAINTENANCE — [CORE PRELIMS + CORE MAINS]

CONTEXT + EXACT CORE

A drain is most informative when read with its connection: a house outlet, a street channel, brick lining and a probable cleaning route collectively show an infrastructure system.

MECHANISM / ARGUMENT

Town planning means more than a grid seen from above.

CONSEQUENCE / CONTRAST

Calling a raised sector a "citadel" does not prove that it was a royal fort.

UPSC TRAP / ANSWER USE

The label describes an excavator's interpretation, not a text from the inhabitants.

ANSWER LINE: **They do not reveal whether a monarch, council, merchant group or several local authorities organised it.**

39

DEEP TEACHING UNIT 4: THE ECONOMY AS A LINKED SYSTEM — [CORE PRELIMS + CORE MAINS]

CONTEXT + EXACT CORE

Food - craft - measure - exchange is the economic-system memory spine.

MECHANISM / ARGUMENT

Its raw material had to arrive, specialist labour had to shape it, and finished goods had to move or be exchanged.

CONSEQUENCE / CONTRAST

Do not learn crops, beads, weights and trade as disconnected lists.

UPSC TRAP / ANSWER USE

A bead is not just an ornament for a list.

ANSWER LINE: **A Mains paragraph can argue: specialised production and shared metrology indicate an integrated economy, but neither coins nor a named bureaucracy are available to prove a modern market or empire.**

40

DEEP TEACHING UNIT 5: EVIDENCE LADDER FOR SCRIPT, POLITY, SOCIETY AND RELIGION

CONTEXT + EXACT CORE

Use a two-step sentence: "The evidence indicates X because of Y; however, Z remains unresolved because the script is undeciphered and the label is interpretive." This earns analysis without evasiveness.

MECHANISM / ARGUMENT

Use a two-step sentence: "The evidence indicates X because of Y; however, Z remains unresolved because the script is undeciphered and the label is interpretive." This earns analysis without evasiveness.

CONSEQUENCE / CONTRAST

"Undeciphered script" does not license every speculation; it makes the material context more important, not less.

UPSC TRAP / ANSWER USE

Archaeology does not mean "we know nothing"; it means that the strength of a claim changes with the evidence.

ANSWER LINE: **Because the script is undeciphered, they cannot securely name a king, identify a god, translate a law or establish caste.**

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DEEP TEACHING UNIT 6: DE-URBANISATION AS CAUSAL SEQUENCE AND CONTINUITY — [CORE PRELIMS + CORE MAINS]

CONTEXT + EXACT CORE

A 20-marker should move from what changed (urban traits, settlement pattern) - possible interacting causes - regional unevenness - continuity.

MECHANISM / ARGUMENT

A 20-marker should move from what changed (urban traits, settlement pattern) - possible interacting causes - regional unevenness - continuity.

CONSEQUENCE / CONTRAST

Late Harappan communities retained some practices while urban traits and settlement patterns changed.

UPSC TRAP / ANSWER USE

It is not a licence to choose one dramatic event.

ANSWER LINE: **Ghaggar-Hakra debates illustrate the rule: many settlements and changing river/environmental conditions matter, but identification with the Vedic Sarasvati and a civilization-wide causal claim are debated.**

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DEEP TEACHING UNIT 7: SITE MEMORY METHOD AND THE FIVE-SENTENCE ANSWER — [CORE PRELIMS + CORE MAINS]

CONTEXT + EXACT CORE

The method works even when one option is partly familiar.

MECHANISM / ARGUMENT

In an unfamiliar site question, do not search memory for one glamorous object.

CONSEQUENCE / CONTRAST

Add a qualifier when a feature is a conventional function, not a settled fact.

UPSC TRAP / ANSWER USE

More sites do not necessarily make a better answer.

ANSWER LINE: **Memory improves when a site is stored as a triad rather than as an isolated name.**